

1021

TALE OF GENJI WRITTEN

Considered to be the first Japanese novel, the *Tale of Genji* took Princess Murasaki Shikibu ten years to complete. The work is an exquisite examination of the life, customs, and etiquette of Heian Japan at the height of the Fujiwara Regency. The story is seen through the eyes of a courtier, Genji, a member of the royal family who is demoted to the rank of commoner.

◁ *Butterflies*, a chapter from *The Tale of Genji* depicted on a panelled screen



1031 The Umayyad caliphate of Córdoba collapses, beset by civil war

1040

SELJUQS DEFEAT THE GHAZNAVIDS

The Seljuqs – originally nomadic Oghuz Turks from Central Asia – invaded Khurasan (territories in modern Iran, Turkmenistan, and Afghanistan) in 1037. Led by Tughril Beg, they defeated the Ghaznavids at Dandanaqan in 1040. After the Ghaznavid sultan Mas'ud fled to India, the Seljuqs began establishing a new Islamic empire that would ultimately stretch as far as Asia Minor.



△ The Battle of Dandanaqan

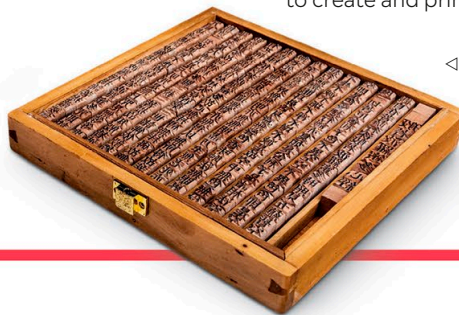
“Real things in the darkness seem no more real than dreams.”

TALE OF GENJI, MURASAKI SHIKIBU, 1021

1041-48

INVENTION OF MOVABLE TYPE

Wooden blocks had long been used in China to print whole pages, but Bi Sheng, a Song dynasty artisan, devised a system in which blocks, each inscribed with a single character, could be arranged and rearranged to create and print many different pages of text.



◁ *Movable type*, hand-carved blocks

1049

▷ The Golden Shwedagon Pagoda, Pagan



1044

PRINCE ANAWRAHTA BECOMES KING OF PAGAN

Anawrahta turned his small principality in Upper Burma into a united Burmese empire. He conquered the Mon kingdoms of the south, and expanded north to the borders of Nanzhao and west to Arakan. His conversion to Theravada Buddhism in 1056 led to religious reforms and the building of many pagodas on the Pagan plain, while his strengthening of the army helped secure the future of Burma.